

CHAPTER 46 — The Direction

Tuesday morning, Zoe gave the drive away.

Ruth took the envelope first.

Plain.

Sealed.

Zoe had written her name across the flap.

ZOE

Not P06-11803.

Not A17-04221.

Not an account number.

Ruth checked the seal.

"This stays with me separately."

"Not with the drive."

"Not with the drive."

"And if that changes?"

"I tell you."

Zoe nodded.

Then she handed over the hard drive.

That went somewhere else.

Ruth had arranged for an evidence officer to meet them at a secure office used for protected material. Child information would remain restricted. The original would be preserved. Anyone accessing protected material would leave a record.

The explanation had taken much longer.

Zoe had argued about most of it. Now there was only the handover

form. The evidence officer turned it towards her. Zoe signed. Her handwriting looked smaller than she expected. The officer placed the drive in a clear evidence bag. Sealed it. Marked the time. 09:42. Then looked at the black backpack on the table. "Do you want that back?"

Zoe stared at it. Cheap. Scuffed. One strap worn paler where it had rubbed against her shoulder for weeks. The folder was gone. The drive was gone. The notebook sat in her coat pocket. The backpack suddenly looked like a bag. Nothing more. "Yes."

The officer handed it over. Zoe put it on.

Too light.

That felt wrong.

Elias stood near the door.

He said nothing.

Outside, Zoe made it three streets before she realised she had checked the zip twice.

The third time, her hand stopped halfway.

Elias noticed.

Still nothing.

"You can say it."

"What?"

"There's nothing in there."

"Something is."

She frowned.

He pointed at the side pocket.

Zoe opened it.

The fantasy book.

The dragon on the cover.

She laughed.

“Important evidence.”

“Clearly.”

She put it back.

They kept walking.

* * *

Jackie chose the café.

Small place beside a park.

Public.

Busy without being loud.

No cameras waiting.

No journalist.

No investigator.

No statement disguised as a reunion.

Claire sat at another table because Jackie was still thirteen and still under safeguarding protection.

Elias waited outside.

His choice.

Zoe arrived first.

She hated that immediately.

Waiting made everything too large.

She ordered hot chocolate because ordering coffee would have been stupid and she was not going to become one of those thirteen-year-olds who thought bitterness counted as adulthood.

She sat.

Stood.

Sat again.

At twelve oh six, the door opened.

Jackie walked in.

Green coat.

Her own.

The sleeves fit.

Zoe noticed that before anything else.

Then Jackie smiled.

Not the enormous smile she used when everything was terrible and she wanted everyone else to stop noticing.

Smaller.

Careful.

Real.

Zoe stood.

Jackie pointed at her.

"If you run at me, I leave."

Zoe stopped.

"I wasn't."

"You were."

"Unproven."

"That is annoying."

"I learned from experts."

They stood three feet apart.

Then Jackie said:

"You can hug me."

Zoe did.

Not running.

No one clapped.

No music appeared from nowhere.

Just two girls in a café holding on harder than either had intended. Jackie cried first. Zoe would later challenge the accuracy of that account. There were no reliable witnesses. When they separated, Jackie wiped her face. "Your hair is awful."

"So is yours."

"Mine was cut by professionals."

"Criminal professionals?"

"Probably not."

They sat. For a while neither spoke. Zoe had rehearsed things. Most of them now sounded ridiculous. She looked at Jackie. "I'm sorry."

Jackie's smile disappeared. "I thought you kept choosing them."

"I know."

"I hated you."

"I know."

Zoe looked at the table. "I decided what you'd done before I knew."

Jackie picked up a sugar packet. Turned it over between her fingers. "You didn't know."

"That doesn't make it nice."

"No."

"I'm still sorry."

Jackie considered that. Then nodded once. Not absolution. Enough to continue. She tore open the sugar packet and emptied it into an empty cup. Zoe stared. "You don't have a drink."

"I am preparing."

"For what?"

"Sugar."

"That isn't an answer."

"It's the only one you need."

Zoe narrowed her eyes. "You've been talking to Elias."

"Unfortunately."

The waiter arrived. Jackie ordered chips.

At noon.

Zoe stared again.

"What?"

"Nothing."

"Judge silently."

"Strongly."

Jackie smiled.

This time Zoe did too.

* * *

Jackie's siblings were alive.

That sentence had once been everything.

Now it was not enough.

Her brother had grown seven centimetres.

One sister had become obsessed with drawing horses despite being

very bad at drawing horses.

The youngest still hated peas.

The missing front tooth was already growing back.

No addresses.

No placement details.

Jackie had chosen what she wanted to know and what she was not ready to know.

She had spoken to her brother on video for twelve minutes.

"He spent four minutes pretending the connection was bad."

"Was it?"

"No."

"Why?"

"He was crying."

Zoe looked at her. "What did you do?"

"Pretended the connection was bad."

"Obviously."

"Exactly."

Jackie ate a chip. "The youngest remembers my voice most."

"Not your face?"

"Bits."

Zoe nodded. She did not say that was sad. Jackie knew. "I don't know if we'll all live together."

"You don't have to know now."

Jackie gave her a suspicious look. "Who are you?"

"Shut up."

"I used to think all four of us in one house was the only good ending."

"And now?"

Jackie shrugged.

"Maybe contact first. Maybe they stay where they are if they're safe. Maybe later something changes."

"Okay."

Jackie froze.

Zoe immediately regretted it.

"You said okay."

"So?"

"You hate okay."

"I'm growing as a person."

"Awful."

They smiled.

Then Jackie looked down at the chips.

"I don't want to be their mother again."

Zoe stayed quiet.

"I love them."

"I know."

"I'll look after them."

"I know."

Jackie swallowed.

"But I was six."

Zoe felt something tighten behind her ribs.

Jackie looked out towards the park.

"I want to be their sister."

Zoe nodded.

"You should get to."

Jackie looked back at her.

"Yeah."

"Yeah."

Then Zoe stole a chip.

Jackie slapped her hand.

Normal enough.

* * *

Cain was charged first.

The current allegations were easier to define than the history.

Jackie's detention.

Her movement under disputed and allegedly false authority.

Interference with safeguarding.

Coercion connected to threats involving her siblings.

Historic offences remained under investigation.

Mac was charged later that week in connection with fraudulent placement records, conspiracy and financial arrangements.

His cooperation continued.

So did the case against him.

Voss and Vale remained under investigation too. Their signed accounts helped establish what had happened.

They also established what they themselves had done.

Westmere's review widened without pretending every historic case was corrupt.

Some restricted cases were confirmed legitimate.

Others needed further examination.

North Vale found more authority references that required checking.

Required checking.

Not instant proof.

The story became less dramatic as professionals took over.

Zoe preferred it that way.

* * *

Helen and Brian remained in their house.

That was almost harder to understand than an arrest.

Zoe sat across from Ruth one afternoon while rain crawled down the office window.

"Can they contact me?"

"Not directly unless you want that."

"What happens to the house?"

"Nothing automatically."

Zoe hesitated.

"My room?"

Ruth's expression changed slightly.

"As far as I know, it's still there."

That hurt.

Bedroom.

Not placement.

Not receiving household.

Her room.

Posters.

Cracked lamp.

The grey jumper she kept forgetting to throw away.

Five years did not vanish because the first decision had been wrong.

Ruth said:

"They've both written to you."

"Separate?"

"Yes."

"Not evidence statements."

"No. These are for you."

Zoe stared at the rain.

"Has Helen asked to see me?"

"Through her solicitor. She asked whether you might consider contact at some point. She said she would accept no."

"Brian?"

"The same."

"What's in the letters?"

"I haven't read them."

"Probably sorry."

"Probably."

"Useless word."

"Sometimes."

Zoe thought of Helen cooking dinner.

Brian swearing a badly fixed bathroom cabinet would last another year.

The observation room. Mac. Helen's phone call. Brian agreeing. Love. Taking. Both. "Not yet." Ruth nodded. Zoe added: "Don't destroy them." "I won't." That was all.

* * *

Three days later, Zoe changed her mind. Partly. "First page." Ruth placed Helen's envelope on the table. "Only the first?" "Yes." "Okay." Zoe pointed at her. "Careful."

Ruth smiled.

Zoe opened the envelope.

Helen had written by hand.

The first sentence filled almost two lines.

I am not going to begin by telling you how much I love you, because you asked me not to make this about that.

Zoe stopped.

Annoying.

Helen had listened.

She read the next line.

I knew enough to say no. I said yes instead.

She read that twice.

Then:

I cannot make the choice smaller by telling you what I was grieving, what I had lost, or what I believed I could give you. Those things explain me. They do not give me the right to have chosen for you or for the family you came from.

Zoe folded the page.

“That’s enough.”

Ruth reached for the envelope.

Zoe gave it back.

Brian’s remained unopened.

Not today.

Possibly not tomorrow.

The world continued anyway.

* * *

The protected accommodation came through current safeguarding.

Small.

Temporary.

Ordinary enough to be strange.

Ruth had made sure Zoe understood who could know the location and why. Claire had explained the practical rules. None of them pretended the arrangement was permanent.

Elias had a separate room down the corridor.

Not inside hers.

The first time Zoe slept in the same building two nights in a row, she woke at three in the morning convinced she had forgotten something.

No move planned.

No tracker.

No car change.

No new name.

No checkout before breakfast.

She lay still.

Pipe.

Car outside.

Someone snoring through a wall.

Normal.

Her body disagreed.

She got dressed and went downstairs.

The night receptionist looked up.

"Everything all right?"

"Yes."

Not exactly. But nothing was attacking her either. She sat by the window. At three seventeen, the lift opened. Elias came out wearing a T-shirt and shoes without socks. Zoe looked him up and down. "You sensed a disturbance in the force?"

"I heard the lift."

"Disappointing."

He sat opposite. Did not ask what was wrong. After a while Zoe said: "What if normal feels wrong forever?"

"It won't."

She looked at him. "You don't know that."

"No."

He rubbed his face. "It may for a while."

Better. Zoe pulled her sleeves over her hands.

"Jackie says the boring house is too quiet."

"Understandable."

"She sleeps with the radio on."

"You could try it."

"I might."

"Okay."

Zoe looked at him.

Then smiled a little.

He did not ask why.

Good.

* * *

Elias went to a doctor.

He told Zoe afterward.

That was how she found out.

Not because she counted tablets.

Not because she checked bottles.

The doctor knew about the rib pain.

The old physical dependence.

His fear of repeating it.

Part of the pain plan changed.

Nothing miraculous happened.

Elias still hurt.

He also took what he had been prescribed instead of trying to prove something by refusing it.

Zoe did not comment.

She had enough people to manage.

* * *

Two weeks after Daniel's article, Ruth asked:

"What name do you want used in the proceedings?"

Zoe frowned.

"My name."

"Which one?"

That stopped her.

Zoe.

The earlier name in the folder.

The identity assigned after everything changed.

The one before it.

Ruth did not rush.

"Some records may need correcting eventually. You do not have to settle every part of that today."

"What if I keep Zoe?"

"You can."

"Even if somebody else chose it first?"

"Yes."

"What if I want to know the other name too?"

"You can."

"What if I don't want to pick one and throw the other away?"

Ruth leaned back.

"Then don't."

Zoe looked at the desk.

Knowing where she came from did not mean she had to become a stranger overnight.

Keeping Zoe did not mean Helen and Brian still owned the decision.

"Use Zoe."

Ruth wrote it down.

"And keep the other one private."

"Yes."

"Where I can get it."

"Yes."

"Not Daniel."

"No."

"Not anyone who doesn't need it."

"Agreed."

Zoe watched Ruth write.

An adult recording what Zoe wanted.

Still strange.

Less strange every time.

* * *

Jackie returned to school first.

Different school.

Temporary.

She hated it immediately.

A teacher asked the class to write about resilience. Jackie refused on principle. The teacher gave her coastal erosion instead. Jackie considered this proof that institutions were capable of learning. Zoe laughed so hard she had to hang up and call back. Zoe's own schooling restarted more slowly. Tutor first. Maths. English. Science. She discovered that surviving a conspiracy did not improve algebra. Deeply unfair.

* * *

The article stopped being front-page news. Faster than Zoe expected. Other things happened. The world continued. The investigations did too. Westmere's review widened. Other authorities checked old restricted records against original legal files. Some came back clean. Some did not. Some remained uncertain.

No magical number appeared to explain everything.

Nobody honest claimed the job was finished.

Zoe stopped reading comments.

Best decision she had made all month.

* * *

One afternoon, she and Jackie sat on a bench beside the park.

Claire was still nearby.

Not very nearby.

Progress.

A dog was attempting to drag a stick through railings despite the stick being wider than the gap.

It had failed several times and remained committed.

Jackie watched it.

"Do you forgive them?"

Zoe knew who.

"No."

"Do you hate them?"

"Sometimes."

"Useful."

"Very."

"What are you going to do?"

"I don't know."

Jackie nodded.

Zoe looked at her.

"What?"

"Nothing."

"You sound like Elias."

"Insulting."

The dog tried again.

Still impossible.

Jackie said:

"I thought getting away would feel bigger."

"Same."

"Like a door."

"Yeah."

"It mostly feels like paperwork."

"Lots of paperwork."

"Terrible ending."

Zoe smiled.

"Maybe getting away isn't the ending."

Jackie looked at her.

Zoe watched the dog abandon the stick and run off after something else.

"You can get out of a room and still have everyone deciding what happens next."

"True."

“So being outside isn’t enough.”

“What is?”

Zoe thought about it.

Ruth asking what she wanted. Jackie saying no. A bathroom lock. A sealed letter. A name she did not have to surrender. A drive she no longer carried. “Agency.”

Jackie made a face. “That sounds like homework.”

“It means choice.”

“I know what it means.”

“Then why ask?”

“I wanted a better word.”

“There isn’t one.”

Jackie sighed. “Terrible.”

Zoe smiled. The opposite of captivity was agency. They watched the dog come back without the stick.

* * *

Elias packed on a Thursday. Zoe knew before he told her. His bag sat on the chair.

Not much inside. Elias had never owned enough for dramatic packing. She stood in the doorway. “Where are you going?”

He looked up. “Need to sort a few things.”

“That is evasive.”

“Yes.”

“Try again.”

He zipped the bag. “The immediate threat has changed.”

“Not gone.”

"No."

"You think I'm safe enough."

"Safer."

"And?"

Elias looked at her. "You don't need me in the same way."

Zoe stared at him. "That wasn't the question."

"No."

"Where are you going?"

"Home eventually."

"Which one?"

He almost smiled. "Fair."

She stepped into the room. "You keep deciding that leaving is safer for everyone else."

His expression changed. "Usually is."

"Not this time."

Silence. No evidence. No plan. Nothing Zoe could prove. Elias said:
"Zoe."

"No."

He stopped. "You don't get to decide for me that I'm better without you."

"I didn't say better."

"You were going to say safer."

"Possibly."

"Same problem."

"It isn't."

"It is when you're making my decision as well."

Elias sat on the edge of the bed. His bag remained beside him. Zoe said: "If you want to leave, say you want to leave."

He looked at her. "If you're tired of this, say that."

Nothing. "But don't turn leaving into something you're doing for me."

The room went quiet. Zoe waited. He could still go. That had to remain true. Finally Elias said: "I don't know how to stay without becoming responsible for everything."

Her anger changed shape. She sat in the chair opposite him. "Then don't."

He looked up. "Don't what?"

"Be responsible for everything."

"You're thirteen."

"I noticed."

"There will be decisions I have to make."

"Yes."

"Times I know more than you."

"Yes."

"Immediate danger."

"You say move now. I move."

"And afterward?"

"You explain."

He watched her. "And the rest?"

"We work it out."

"That simple?"

"No."

“Good.”

Zoe leaned back. “Simple answers are suspicious.”

That almost got a laugh. Almost. She looked at his bag. “Do you want to leave?”

Elias took a long time. “No.”

Something in Zoe’s chest hurt in a way she did not entirely dislike. “Then unpack.”

He looked at her. “Bossy.” “Agency.” “That is not what agency means.” “It does today.” Elias laughed. Actually laughed. Then opened the bag. He took out a shirt. Then another. Not everything. Enough.

* * *

Saturday morning, the cheap phone buzzed while Zoe was eating toast. She looked at the screen. Ruth. A short update. Cain’s next hearing date. Another historic authority reference confirmed for formal review. Nothing requiring Zoe that day. Zoe read it once. Turned the phone off. Elias watched from across the table.

“No reply?” “Nothing to say.” She dropped it into the backpack beside the fantasy book. The bag contained water. Crisps. The book. A switched-off phone. Nothing anyone would kill for. “Walk?” Elias asked. Zoe looked out of the window. “Why?” He shrugged. “Because.” Suspicious. Acceptable.

* * *

The path outside town followed a hedge for nearly a mile before splitting. Left climbed towards a ridge. Right dropped towards a river. A wooden sign gave distances Zoe had not bothered memorising. Elias stopped at the junction. Zoe stopped beside him. The backpack hung loose from one shoulder.

“Which way?” he asked.

Zoe looked at the ridge. Then at the river. “What do you think?”

Elias glanced at her. Then towards the paths. “River.”

“Why?”

“Less uphill.”

“Strong argument.”

“I thought so.”

Zoe looked towards the river. Then back at the ridge. “I want the view.”

“Then ridge.”

“You said river.”

“You asked what I thought.”

“So?”

“So now you decide.”

Zoe frowned. “No.”

Elias waited. “We decide.”

He looked at both paths again. “Ridge first. River on the way back.”
Zoe considered. “Acceptable.” They turned left.